

2, A Compromise Emerged During the Great Islamic Conquests

A highly crucial question is: During the very initial stage of the Islamic conquests—namely, within the 7th century—did the Arab nation already possess the conditions for *feudalization* (封建化)?

Why do I raise this question? Because it is a clear fact that the Arab Empire established under the rule of the Caliphs in the 7th century was far from a feudal state. Rather, it was an empire of a classical nature, built upon the full absorption of the preexisting classical bureaucratic systems (those of Byzantium and Sassanid Persia) in the Middle East. (*Perhaps the term **Near East** / 近东 is more historically appropriate for events of that era, but I will uniformly use the modern designation "Middle East" in the following sections.*)

Certain historical facts vividly demonstrate the bizarre nature of this entire process. When the second Rashidun Caliph, Umar ibn al-Khattab (欧麦尔), rapidly conquered Persian and Byzantine territories, the Caliphate explicitly mandated that Arab Muslims were strictly prohibited from owning land in the newly conquered territories outside the Arabian Peninsula. Instead, a nearly egalitarian distribution method was adopted for war spoils and the tax revenues of the newly conquered lands, enabling the conquerors to reap economic benefits.

In my view, this behavior somewhat resembles the Manchu Eight Banners, where military democratization was more pronounced. But even so, was such a strict prohibition on land ownership excessively extreme?

Subsequent facts indicate that this event cannot be entirely explained by the Arabian society being "too backward" to possess the intrinsic drive for land appropriation. Because after the establishment of the Umayyad dynasty (伍麦叶王朝), this prohibition had already been breached; the Arabs always found ways to acquire land in Iraq, Iran, Syria, and even Egypt.

On the other hand, even if the Arabs lacked the sufficient conditions for *feudalization* at the onset of the conquests, this does not prevent us from making the following judgment: **In the initial stages of the conquest, the Muslim rulers struck a compromise with the conquered populace—a compromise strikingly similar to what occurred in China.**

This is because, even though social conditions possess attributes of natural evolution, human beings can absolutely utilize subjective agency (主观能动性) to accelerate and actualize their emergence.

For instance, when we note the various Germanic tribes first breaching the Roman borders, did they truly possess the sufficient conditions for *feudalization*? The fact is, the social developmental level of these tribes was far inferior even to that of the Arabian Peninsula when Muhammad first began preaching!

Southern Arabia possessed relatively superior conditions for irrigated agriculture, with state regimes existing for a millennium. Although the central region was essentially a desert studded with oases, trade networks permeated it, rendering the region's interactions with the outside world quite substantial. The Arabs had already been influenced by Judaism and Christianity. In the 6th century, regimes like the Kingdom of Kindah (肯德王朝) had already begun attempting to unify the Arab tribes of the central and northern peninsula, and tribal communal ownership and blood-tie systems were moving toward disintegration.

These facts amply demonstrate (*and the relevant works I have read explicitly concede*) that on the eve of Muhammad's creation of Islam, the era was indeed calling for a unified Arab nation-state. Islam was born precisely to adapt to this overarching historical momentum.

This makes things all the more perplexing: **Since what the era called for was an Arab nation-state, why was the final outcome a classical Caliphate?**

A prominent characteristic of a classical state is that it is a **universal empire** (普世帝国). Rome and Persia go without saying, but even the Qin and Han empires were exactly the same—it is merely China's subsequent historical trajectory that makes it so easy for people to forget this point.

From Emperor Gaozu to Emperor Wu, the Han Empire centralized the ancestral sacrifices of the various former vassal kingdoms in Chang'an. Emperor Wu even had to continuously employ the strategy of frequent eastern inspection tours (东巡) to pacify the former territories of Qi, Yan, and Chu in the east. Not to mention the empire conquered vast territories of non-Huaxia peoples such as the Baiyue, Baipu, Xiongnu, and Donghu; surrendered Xiongnu figures like Jin Midi (金日磾) could even hold high imperial office.

The Han nationality was still in the process of integration and formation during China's classical era. The reason people are accustomed to tracing the foundation of the nation back to the Han Dynasty is largely because China never went through a complete **feudal period** (封建时代).

However, the Umayyad dynasty, which inherited the civil service systems of the conquered lands, heavily relied on Syrians; the subsequent Abbasid dynasty (阿拔斯王朝), having relocated its capital to Mesopotamia, heavily relied on Persians. **This obviously diverges light-years away from an Arab nation-state!**

If we consider the situation in the Arabian Peninsula post-conquest, it feels even more bizarre. After the Caliphate was established, the regions with the most frequent and fierce rebellions were not the newly conquered territories, but the Arabian Peninsula itself—Yemen, Oman, Bahrain, and even the Two Holy Cities (the Hejaz / 两圣地)!

On the eve of the rise of the Wahhabi movement (瓦哈比运动) in the early modern era, the Arabian Peninsula was still mired in a state of political chaos and backward production. Even idolatry, which was strictly and explicitly prohibited by Islam, actually ran rampant once again! It was practically indistinguishable from the era before the Prophet began his preaching.

Furthermore, some more direct evidence proves that a compromise likely indeed occurred. For example, Hasan ibn Ali (哈桑), the eldest son of Ali ibn Abi Talib (阿里), reached a compromise with Mu'awiya (穆阿维叶), relinquishing his claim to the Caliphate in exchange for an exceedingly lucrative annuity. Naturally, this had to be bankrolled by the tax revenues extracted from the conquered regions.

The rapid and massive fragmentation of Islamic sects makes this dynamic even more suspicious. Although the primary motive for the early Islamic schisms was over who had the right to succeed as Caliph and what succession system should be followed, *were there underlying economic interests driving these seemingly political motives?* For instance, were there certain factions of Arab Muslims who felt profoundly dissatisfied with the empire's policy of compromise toward the conquered?

Moreover, the contradictions regarding the successor practically provided a crucial motive for the emergence of this compromise.

When the Prophet Muhammad passed away, although he left behind the religious banner of Islam, the political institutional construction of the Islamic state had not yet been established in time—most notably, there was a glaring absence of systems and institutions regarding succession.

Consequently, one easily notices a stark reality: although the Prophet left behind a vigorous, formidable armed military group, it was not long before there were simply too many claimants to the Caliphate!

Whoever seized leadership had to confront a daunting dilemma: he needed to rely on his own capabilities to advance the Islamic conquests to satisfy the Arab Muslims' thirst for spoils of war, **yet he dared not push overly radical *feudalization* policies in the conquered territories.** This was because there were simply too many rivals coveting the throne. If a competitor postured a willingness to compromise with the ruling class of the conquered territories, the ruling Caliph would immediately find himself caught in a deadly crossfire from both within and without (内外夹击).

Therefore, choosing compromise appeared fundamentally necessary for the rulers' own survival.

In the beginning, the Arab conquerors not only refrained from expropriating the lands of the conquered, but did not even force any alteration to the local people's original faiths. The Arab Empire inherited the bureaucratic systems of Byzantium and Persia, utilizing these classical institutions to extract wealth from across the empire. A paramount purpose of this wealth was to "**co-opt**" (收买 / **buy off**) the Arab warriors serving as the pillars of the conquest, as well as the rivals coveting the throne.

I noted that after the conquests, the aristocracy of the Two Holy Cities indeed became addicted to the dividends distributed by the empire. Not only did they trend toward extravagant decadence, but they also began losing their martial spirit in politics. From the mid-8th century onward, the vanguard of the Islamic conquests was no longer the Arabs, but gradually shifted to peoples like the Berbers (柏柏尔人) who converted to Islam after being conquered.

Therefore, although the martial prowess of the Islamic conquests was illustrious, it did not significantly propel the social progress of the Arabian Peninsula, **because the organic demand for national *feudalization* was suppressed.** It was not until a millennium later, when the entire Islamic world faced the relentless encroachment of the West and mounting social crises, that this long-shelved demand resurfaced in the form of fundamentalism (原教旨主义).

In light of the above, I am inclined to conclude that the Arab nation basically possessed the conditions for ***feudalization*** at the onset of the conquests. It was only dictated by the circumstances of the times that the Muslim rulers, through compromise, adopted bureaucratizing measures (continuing the classical systems of the Middle East), causing this feudal endeavor to be shelved for a prolonged period. *(Of course, the other side of this "compromise" was also based on the developmental conditions of Near Eastern society itself, which will be addressed in the next chapter).*

It was definitely not the case that they completely lacked the conditions for **feudalization** at the start of the conquest. It was only in the 10th and 11th centuries, when the impact of the Great Turkic Migrations (突厥大迁徙) became exceptionally prominent, that the Middle East pivoted toward comprehensive **feudalization**.

Looking back from the perspective of later generations, the bureaucratization of the Arab Empire exerted a colossal impact on human history. The continuation of classical society in the Middle East meant that although Byzantium lost Egypt and the Levant (黎凡特), it did not face a two-front assault from feudalized regimes. Consequently, the remnants of this classical empire managed to survive much longer.

The bureaucratization of the Arab Empire actually placed a constraint on the expansion of Islam, **because there is a natural upper limit to the territorial expanse a classical empire can effectively control**. The establishment of the empire simultaneously marked the end of the first phase of Islamic conquests.

By the time the second phase of Islamic expansion commenced at the dawn of the second millennium AD, the dominance had already shifted into the hands of the newly converted, **feudalized barbarians** (突厥等蛮族). This marked the era of **feudal Islamic expansion**.

The most fascinating phenomenon forged by the classical Arab Empire lies in its developmental **"asynchrony"** (时差 / **temporal lag**). When Europe generally entered the Early Middle Ages, the classical Islamic society of the Middle East functioned to preserve and transmit the achievements of Mediterranean classical civilization.

This is highly understandable. The high urbanization rates, developed commercial activities, and the openness, tolerance, and rationalism inherent to a **universal empire** certainly hold a special place in human history. Naturally, these traits inevitably experience an **ebb tide** (退潮) during the early stages of **feudalization**, which constitutes a loss for civilization.

However, because the Arab Empire prolonged the Middle East's exceedingly lengthy classical period, the conquerors—being the relatively backward party—had to draw upon the achievements of the past Mediterranean classical civilizations to rule such a colossal state. Consequently, an inevitable outcome was that the Arab Empire possessed immense enthusiasm for translating, preserving, and expanding upon the civilizational fruits of the Greco-Roman era.

By the time the Islamic world generally entered the early stages of **feudalization**, Europe had already advanced to the High Middle Ages. The completion of societal reconfiguration equipped the Western world with the conditions to rediscover these classical civilizational achievements.

(Of course, to my knowledge, when medieval Europe rediscovered the civilizational achievements of ancient Greece and Rome, they did not actually rely on translations from the Islamic world for primary sources; in reality, the Islamic world did not translate that many Greco-Roman works. What truly mattered was that the Islamic world made numerous innovations while studying and absorbing Mediterranean classical civilization, and these new discoveries proved highly valuable to the ascending Europeans).

Thus, we can assert that the Islamic society's noble deed of transmitting and expanding upon classical civilizational achievements during the Middle Ages (*the Middle Ages as defined by*

Europeans) was by no means born of the historical self-awareness of rulers or scholars, but was rather **the inevitable result of the evolution of social formations**.

This also perfectly explains why observers constantly perceive Islam as a tolerant, science-revering religion in its inception, only to become increasingly irrational, extreme, and narrow-minded later on.

This is not to say that the Turks and the subsequent Mongols destroyed a vast amount of social wealth and intellectual culture purely through martial force; rather, it is because ***feudalization* inherently unfolds this way during its initial stages**.

One can also recognize this through the internal mutations of Islam itself. As an Islamic philosopher during the zenith of the Great Turkic Migrations, Al-Ghazali's (安萨里) theories perfectly adapted to the overarching historical trend: **the ebb tide of rationalism during the early stage of *feudalization***, harmoniously integrating Sufi mysticism with orthodox theology.

The emergence of Sufi mysticism and the subsequent massive proliferation of **religious orders** (教団 / Sufi *Tariqas*) visually reflect this historical process even more directly. In the era of ***feudalization***, the general populace loathed convoluted theological debates and intricate paths to salvation; they yearned to attain salvation and spiritual elevation through simple, intuitive experiences.

This is obviously not a phenomenon exclusive to any single religion, but a highly universal one!

The transition from classical Japanese state Buddhism to **Chūsei Buddhism** (中世佛教) perfectly mirrors this. The belief that "*one can be reborn in the Pure Land simply by chanting the name of Amitābha Buddha*" (口念阿弥陀佛便可极乐往生) is the absolute quintessential popular religious consciousness of a ***feudal society*** (封建社会).

The development of Sufi **religious orders** functioned to maintain grassroots social organization. This, alongside the collapse of the Caliphate system, are fundamentally **two sides of the same coin** (一体两面) in the historical process of transitioning from a classical society to a ***feudal society***.

However, having said all that, the classical Arab Empire can hardly be deemed a "good thing" for either the Arab nation or for Islam itself.

Under circumstances where the conditions for ***feudalization*** were already sufficient, utilizing human agency to forcefully delay this historical process by two centuries undeniably constituted a devastating retardation of the Middle East's development.

When the Turkic peoples migrated westward in successive waves, the empire was washed away without possessing the slightest capacity for resistance. The arrival of the Mongols was delayed by merely two more centuries, yet it struck exactly during the most fragile historical phase of early ***feudalization***—after all, the fundamental organizational units of society were disintegrating down to their minimal components, while reconfiguration had not yet begun.

The repeated onslaughts of barbarians plunged the Islamic world of West Asia into severe stagnation during its ***feudal period***, which is clearly another kind of historical tragedy.

Imagine this: if the ***feudalization*** of the Middle East could have commenced two centuries earlier, would an early feudal state dominated by Arabs have had the opportunity to perform better against nomadic shocks?

Regardless, once the Islamic world stepped into **feudal society**, it never managed to climb out of it on its own. Consequently, the Arab Empire's inheritance and expansion of classical civilizational achievements ultimately served as a stepping stone (为他人做嫁衣) for the West. The House of Wisdom (智慧宫) was built using the wealth of the Arab Empire, the researchers within were scholars of the Arab Empire, yet the fruits of this House of Wisdom ultimately benefited Western Europeans!

(This is, of course, a hyperbolic expression. There were naturally many Islamic scholars outside the House of Wisdom who made outstanding contributions; simultaneously, Europeans' understanding of classical civilization fundamentally did not rely on the Islamic world).

This is not to say that without the Arabs transmitting and sublatating (传承和扬弃) the achievements of Greco-Roman civilization, Europe would not have risen to prosperity. These classical achievements are by no means an absolute necessity for modernizing into the early modern era.

Japan is a perfect example: prior to the modern era, the Japanese were arguably entirely ignorant of Greece and Rome, yet Japan smoothly transitioned into an **early modern society** (近代社会). This is ample proof that **what plays the decisive role in historical progression is social structure, not anything else!**

The Arabs' true contribution lay in accelerating Europe's progression from the Middle Ages into the early modern era, which is undeniably impossible to overlook.

As a Chinese person—especially one intimately familiar with Chinese history—my profound resonance with the idiom "**Delay invites disaster**" (迟则生变) cuts to the absolute bone! During the critical periods of social revolution, one must absolutely muster the momentum to smash through all hardships in one vigorous, uninterrupted push (一鼓作气). The longer one drags it out, the easier it becomes to encounter catastrophic variables.

Of course, people today have no right to be overly harsh in accusing the Caliphs and conquerors of that era of being "too weak."

One must not forget that during the Great Islamic Conquests, neither the Eastern Roman Empire nor the Persian Empire was weak by any measure. Had it not been for the prolonged, grueling wars previously fought between these two empires, Islam's armed expansion would never have proceeded so smoothly.

More importantly, one should never forget that the Arab armies possessed absolutely no advantage over their enemies in terms of either manpower or equipment!

If the Muslim leaders had decided to adopt a far more radical **feudalization** route at that exact moment, the conquests would inevitably have become astronomically more difficult and uncertain than the history of our world dictates.

The Arab Empire swiftly took over the bureaucratic systems left behind by the **Late-classical states** (晚期古典国家) in the core regions of Middle Eastern civilization. In relatively peripheral regions, such as Tabaristan (塔布里斯坦), they demanded merely formal submission, completely respecting the original religious beliefs of the massive conquered populations. **These three points were indeed the absolute keys to the swift success of the Great Conquests.**

For the Arabs at that precise historical moment, the risks associated with immediate *feudalization* were simply far too colossal to bear.

2，伊斯兰大征服的过程中出现了妥协

一个非常重要的问题是，在伊斯兰征服的最开始阶段也就是公元七世纪内，阿拉伯民族是否已经具备封建化的条件？为什么我要提出这个问题呢，因为一个清楚的事实是，在七世纪内建立起的哈里发统治的阿拉伯帝国远非一个封建国家，而是在充分接收了中东（对于那个年代的事情来说或许用近东一词更为合适，但是我以下几节统一使用现在的称呼“中东地区”）原有的古典官僚制度（拜占庭和萨珊波斯的）基础上建立的一个古典性质的帝国。一些历史事实充分表明了整个过程的怪异，在第二任正统哈里发欧麦尔（Umar ibn al-Khattab）快速征服波斯和拜占庭领地的时候，哈里发国要求所有阿拉伯穆斯林不允许在阿拉伯半岛之外的新征服地拥有土地，但是在战利品和新征服领地的税收则采取了一种接近平均分配的方式，使得征服者们能够获得经济利益。这种行为，在我看来有一点像军事民主化更明显的满洲八旗，可即使如此严格禁止拥有土地的禁令是否仍然过于极端？后来的事实表明该事件似乎不能够完全解释为阿拉伯社会还太过落后以至于不存在占有土地的内在动力，因为到伍麦叶王朝（Umayyad dynasty，另一种常见翻译为倭马亚王朝）建立之后这个禁令已经被突破了，阿拉伯人总有手段在伊拉克，伊朗，叙利亚甚至埃及取得一些土地。

另一个方面来说，就算阿拉伯人在征服开始的时候并不具备封建化的充分条件，这也不妨碍我们做出这样一个判断：穆斯林统治者在征服的最初阶段与被征服者进行了一种类似在中国发生的妥协。这是因为哪怕社会条件会有自然演化的属性，但是人完全可以凭借主观能动性去加速并实现其产生。例如当我们注意到日耳曼各部落刚开始进入罗马边境的时候，难道他们就具有封建化的充足条件了吗？事实是这些部落的社会发展水平甚至远不如穆罕默德开始传教时的阿拉伯半岛，阿拉伯半岛南部具有条件较为优越的灌溉农业地区，国家政权的存在历史有一千年，中部虽然充其量只是镶嵌着绿洲的沙漠，但是贸易网络遍布其中，这使得整个地区与外界的交流是相当可观的，阿拉伯人已经受到犹太教和基督教的影响。在公元六世纪像肯德王朝这样的政权已经开始做出统一半岛中北部阿拉伯民族的尝试，部落公有制和血缘制也在趋近瓦解。这些事实充分表明（包括我看的有关作品也直言承认），在穆罕默德创建伊斯兰教前夕，时代确实在呼唤一个统一的阿拉伯民族国家，伊斯兰教正是适应这种历史大势而诞生的。如此这般就更令人迷惑，既然时代呼唤的是一个阿拉伯民族国家，为什么最后出现的是一个古典的哈里发国？

古典国家的一个显著特点就是其为普世帝国，罗马和波斯自不必说，哪怕是秦汉帝国亦是如此，只不过是日后中国的历史进程使得人们很容易忘记这一点罢了。自高帝至武帝，汉帝国将原先各个诸侯王国的祭祀集中在长安进行，武帝还必须通过频繁东巡这一策略对于东方的齐燕楚故地进行安抚，更不用说帝国还征服了百越、百濮、匈奴、东胡等非华夏民族的大片领土，金日磾这样的匈奴降人也可身居高位。汉民族于中国的古典时代尚处于整合形成当中，人们之所以习惯于把民族奠基追溯到汉代，很大程度上是中国并没有经过完整的封建时期的原因。然而继承了被征服地文官系统的伍麦叶王朝重用叙利亚人，接下来的阿拔斯王朝因为迁都两河流域重用波斯人，这显然与一个阿拉伯民族国家相去甚远。

如果我们考虑到征服之后阿拉伯半岛的情况就会更觉奇怪，当哈里发国建立之后，反抗最为频繁、激烈的地区不在被征服的领地，而就是在阿拉伯半岛，也门、阿曼、巴林甚至是两圣地。在近代瓦哈比运动兴起前夕，阿拉伯半岛还是一片政治混乱，生产落后的局面，甚至伊斯兰教明令禁止的偶像崇拜竟然又大行其道，简直与先知传道之前没有什么区别。还有一些更为直接的证据证明了妥协可能确实发生，例如阿里（Ali ibn Abi Talib）的长子哈桑（Hasan ibn Ali）就与穆阿维叶（Mu'awiya）妥协，放弃了为哈里发之位的宣称以换取一笔极为优渥的年金，这当然是需要被征服地区的税收进行支持的。伊斯兰教

派系的迅速和大量的分裂使得此事更为可疑，虽然早期伊斯兰教的分裂的主要动机是出于谁能够继任哈里发，哈里发应该遵循怎样的继承制度。但是这种表面上的政治动机背后是否还隐藏着经济利益驱动，例如是否存在一些派别的阿拉伯穆斯林对于帝国的妥协政策感到不满呢？

另外，关于继承人的矛盾在事实上给出了妥协出现的一个重要动机。先知穆罕默德去世时虽然留下的伊斯兰教这一面宗教旗帜，但是伊斯兰国家的政治体制建设并没有来得及进行，特别是缺少有关继承人的制度以及相关机构。因此人们很容易注意到这样一个事实，虽然先知留下来了一个朝气蓬勃的、强有力的军事武装团体，但是不多时对哈里发之位的宣称者就变得太多。获取领导权的人不得不面临这样一种情况，他既需要凭借自己的才干推进伊斯兰征服以满足阿拉伯穆斯林对于战利品的欲望，又不敢在被征服地区推进过于激进的封建化政策。这是因为觊觎宝座的人实在太多，一旦竞争者摆出对于被征服地区的统治阶级进行妥协的姿态，那么自己就会立刻陷入内外夹击的局面。因此统治者选择妥协在其自身看来具有必要性，阿拉伯征服者在最初不但不剥夺被征服者的土地，甚至对当地人民原有的信仰都不予改变。阿拉伯帝国继承了拜占庭和波斯的官僚制度，利用这一套古典体制从帝国各地榨取财富，而这些财富的一个重要用途就是去“收买”作为征服支柱的阿拉伯武士还有觊觎大位的竞争者。我注意到征服后的两圣地的贵族的确沉迷于帝国给予他们的分红，不但有生活奢靡的趋势而且在政治上开始丧失斗志。从八世纪中叶开始，伊斯兰征服的主力就不再是阿拉伯人而逐渐转为柏柏尔人这样在被征服后改宗伊斯兰教的民族。

因此伊斯兰征服的武功虽然显赫，但是却并没有显著推动阿拉伯半岛地区的社会进步，因为民族封建化的需求被压制了。直到一千年后整个伊斯兰世界在面对西方逼近，社会危机日益加重时，这一被搁置了太久的诉求才以原教旨主义的方式重新出现。鉴于以上，我本人倾向于阿拉伯民族在征服开始之时就已经基本具备了封建化的条件，只是时势所至穆斯林统治者经过妥协采取了官僚化（延续中东的古典体制）的措施使这一事业被长期搁置。（当然，“妥协”的另一面还基于近东社会本身的发展情况，这一点将会在下一章提及）并非在征服开始的时候全然不具备封建化的条件，直到公元十、十一世纪突厥大迁徙的影响已经极为显著的时候才转向全面的封建化。站在后世的角度看，阿拉伯帝国的官僚化对人类历史产生了巨大的影响，中东地区古典社会的延续使拜占庭虽然失去了埃及和黎凡特但是却并没有遭到封建化政权的两面夹击，这个古典帝国的残存得以延续更久。阿拉伯帝国的官僚化事实上限制了伊斯兰教的扩张，因为一个古典帝国所能控制的疆域有其自然上限，帝国的成立同时意味着伊斯兰征服的第一个阶段结束。而公元第二个千年开始的伊斯兰教的第二阶段扩张其主导权就已经新近皈依伊斯兰教的封建化蛮族手中，这也就是封建的伊斯兰扩张时期。

古典的阿拉伯帝国所形成的一个最有趣的现象在于发展的“时差”，当欧洲普遍进入中世纪早期时，中东的古典伊斯兰社会起到了对地中海古典文明成果传承和保护的作用。这一点是很容易理解的，古典国家的高城市化率，发达商业活动，作为普世帝国的开放、包容和理性主义在人类历史上的确占有特殊地位，并且在封建化早期这些特质必然会退潮，这对于文明来说是一种损失。然而由于阿拉伯帝国延续了中东极为漫长的古典时期，征服者们作为相对落后的一方为了统治庞大的国家必须借鉴过往地中海地区古典文明的成果，于是一个必然产生的结果是，阿拉伯帝国对于翻译、保存和发扬希腊罗马时期的文明成果具有极大的热情。当伊斯兰世界普遍进入封建化早期阶段之后，欧洲已经发展到了中世纪盛期，社会重构的完成使得西方世界具备了重新认识这些古典文明成果的条件。（当然，据我所知中世纪欧洲在重新认识古希腊和罗马的文明成果时原始文献并不依赖于伊斯兰世界的译本，实际上伊斯兰世界也没有翻译那么多希腊罗马作品。重要的是伊斯兰世界在学习和吸收地中海古典文明成果的同时进行了很多创新，这些新的发现对于崛起的欧洲人就很有价值了）于是我们可以这样说，伊斯兰社会在中世纪（对

欧洲人来说的中世纪）传承并发扬古典文明成果的義举，绝非出于统治者或者学者的历史自觉，而是社会形态演变的必然结果。

这同样可以解释为什么观察者总是认为伊斯兰教在一开始是宽容的，崇尚科学的宗教，到后来却变得不再理性，越来越偏激狭隘，这不是说突厥人和随后的蒙古人凭借武力销毁了多少社会财富和思想文化，而是因为封建化在最初阶段的确是这样发展的。人们从伊斯兰教本身的变动也能意识到这一点，安萨里（Al-Ghazali）作为突厥大迁徙鼎盛时期的伊斯兰哲学家，他的理论就充分适应了封建化早期阶段理性主义退潮的历史大势，将苏菲神秘主义与正统学派相结合。苏菲神秘主义的出现以及随后的教团大兴更加直观反映了这一历史进程，在封建化时代普罗大众厌恶烦琐的教义辩论和救赎之道，希望能够用简单和直观感受的方式获得救赎和升华。这显然不是只在某个宗教出现而是具有普遍性的现象，古典日本的国家佛教向中世佛教的转变充分反映了这一点，“口念阿弥陀佛便可极乐往生”是再典型不过的封建社会的民间宗教意识。苏菲教团的发展起到了维系社会基层组织的作用，这与哈里发制度的崩溃属于古典社会向封建社会转变这一历史进程的一体两面。

可是话又说回来，古典阿拉伯帝国对于阿拉伯民族也好，对于伊斯兰教也好很难说是好事。在封建化的条件已经足够的情况下把这一历史进程又以人力向后推迟了两个世纪，对于中东地区的发展无疑是一种迟滞。当突厥人分批次向西运动的时候，帝国在完全不具备抵抗能力的情况下就被冲垮了。蒙古人的到来仅仅晚了两个多世纪，恰恰赶在了封建早期这一最脆弱的历史阶段，毕竟社会基本构成单元正解体到最小，而重组还没有开始。蛮族的反复冲击使得西亚的伊斯兰世界在封建时期陷入严重停滞，这显然是另一种历史悲剧。试想一下，如果中东地区的封建化能够早两个世纪开始，那么阿拉伯人主导的早期封建国家是否有机会在游牧冲击下表现更好？无论如何，伊斯兰世界一旦走进了封建社会便没有再自己走出来，于是阿拉伯帝国对于古典文明成果的继承和发扬最终为西方做了嫁衣，修建智慧宫用的是阿拉伯帝国的财富，在智慧宫做研究的是阿拉伯帝国的学者，而智慧宫的成果惠及的却是西欧人。（这里只是一个夸张式的说法，智慧宫之外当然也有很多伊斯兰学者做出了杰出贡献，同时欧洲人对古典文明的了解基本上不依赖于伊斯兰世界）当然这不是说没有阿拉伯人对于古希腊罗马文明成果的传承和扬弃欧洲就不会走向兴盛，这些古典成果对于近现代化并非必要，日本就是一个很典型的例子，近代以前日本人可以说对于希腊和罗马一无所知，但是日本照样进入了近世社会，这足以说明对于历史进程起到决定性作用的是社会结构而非其他。阿拉伯人的贡献在于加快了欧洲从中世纪向近世的进程，这当然也是不可忽视的，作为一个中国人，特别是了解中国历史的中国人，我对于“迟则生变”这四个字的感受实在太过深刻，在社会革命的关键时期一定要拿出一鼓作气踏平艰险的势头，拖的时间越长就越容易遇到各种意外。

当然，现在的人们没有办法苛求当年的哈里发和征服者们“太过软弱”。人们不应忘记伊斯兰大征服之时，不管是东罗马帝国还是波斯帝国都绝非弱小，如果不是之前两个帝国之间长久激烈的战争，伊斯兰教的武装扩张不会那么顺利。人们更不应该忘记，阿拉伯军队不管是在数量上和装备上与他们的敌人比并不占优势。如果穆斯林的领导人决定在那个时刻就开始采取更为激进的封建化路线，那么征服必然比我们这个世界的历史变得更加困难和不确定。阿拉伯帝国在中东文明的核心地区迅速接手了晚期古典国家留下的官僚体制，在相对边缘的地区，比如塔布里斯坦则只要求形式上的臣服，尊重了被征服的庞大人口原本的宗教信仰，这三点的确是大征服得以迅速成功的关键。而封建化对于当时的阿拉伯人来说，风险实在是过于巨大了。